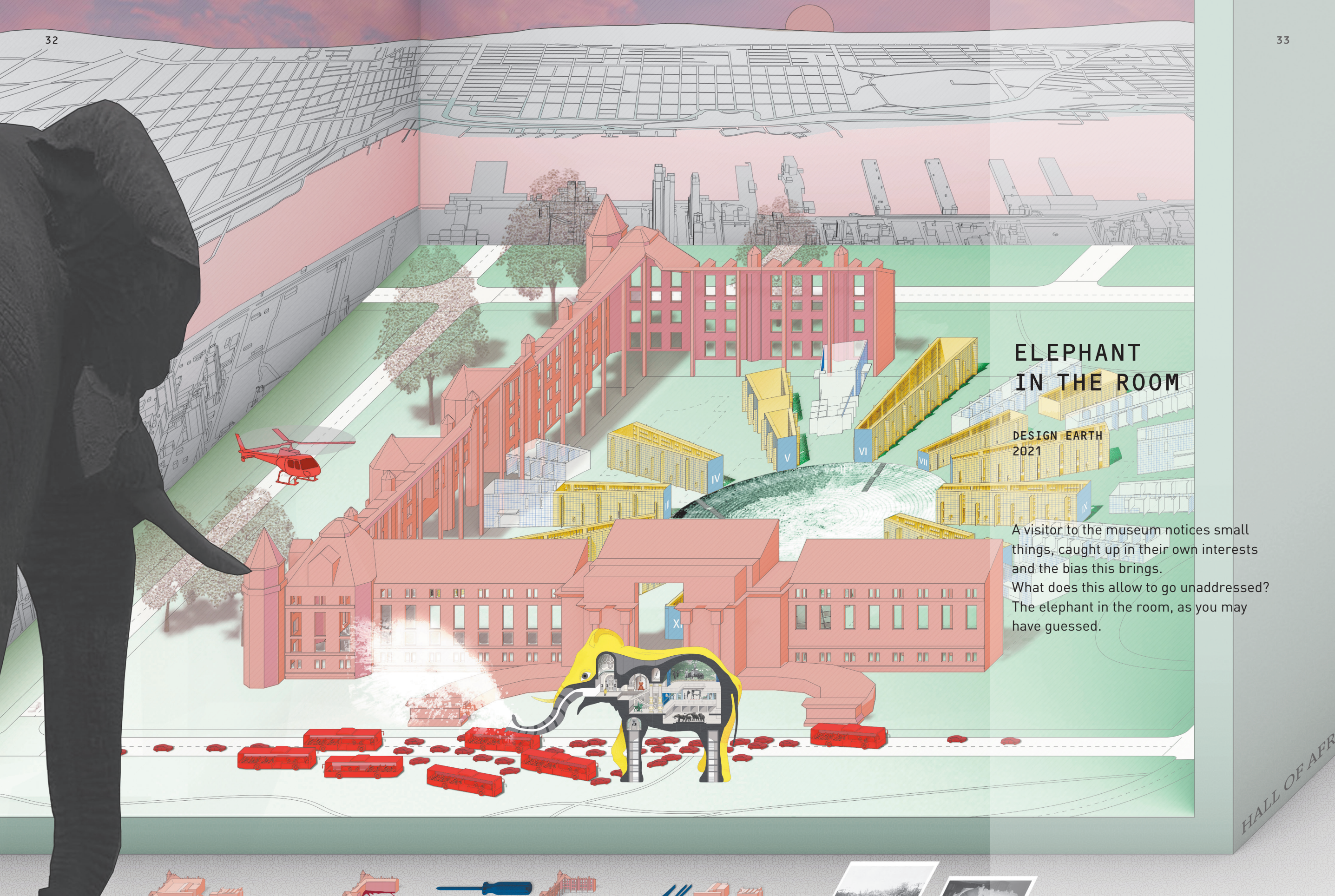


Edited by Leire Asensio Villoria & David Mah

THE CLIMATE IMAGINARY

This book examines a broader shift towards climate as a primary motivator of design practice. A close study of exemplary projects informs the articulation of broader themes associated with contemporary climate imaginary practices.

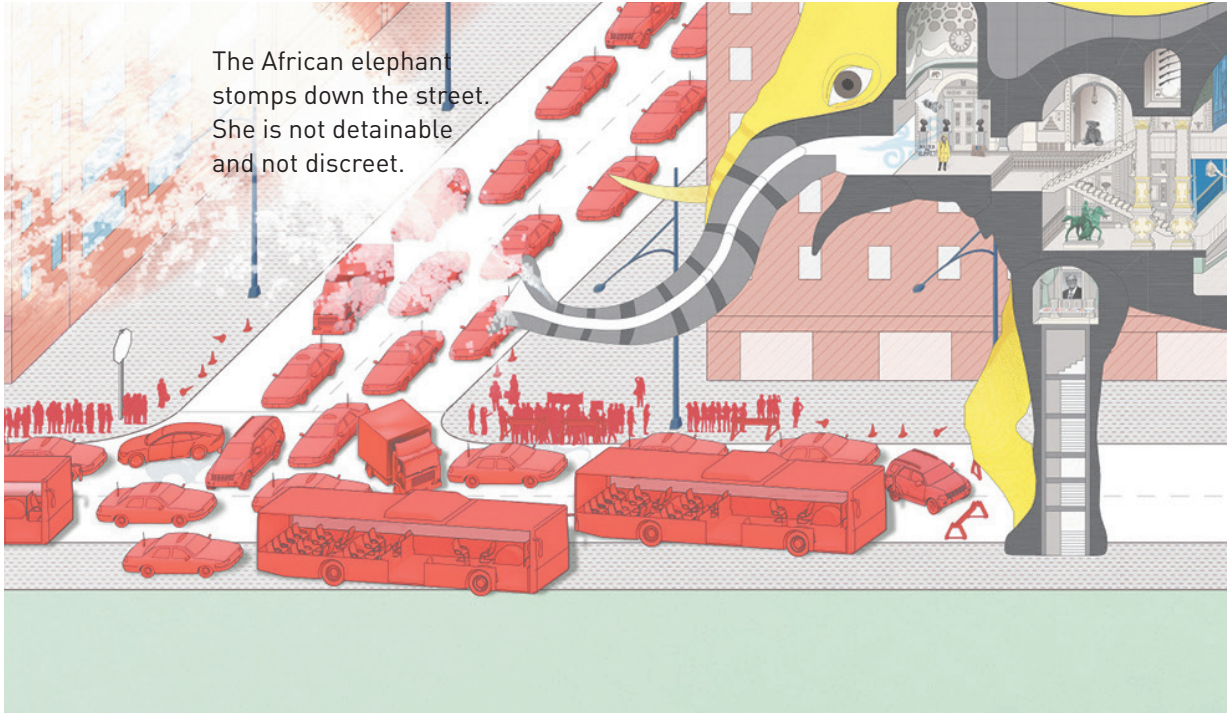
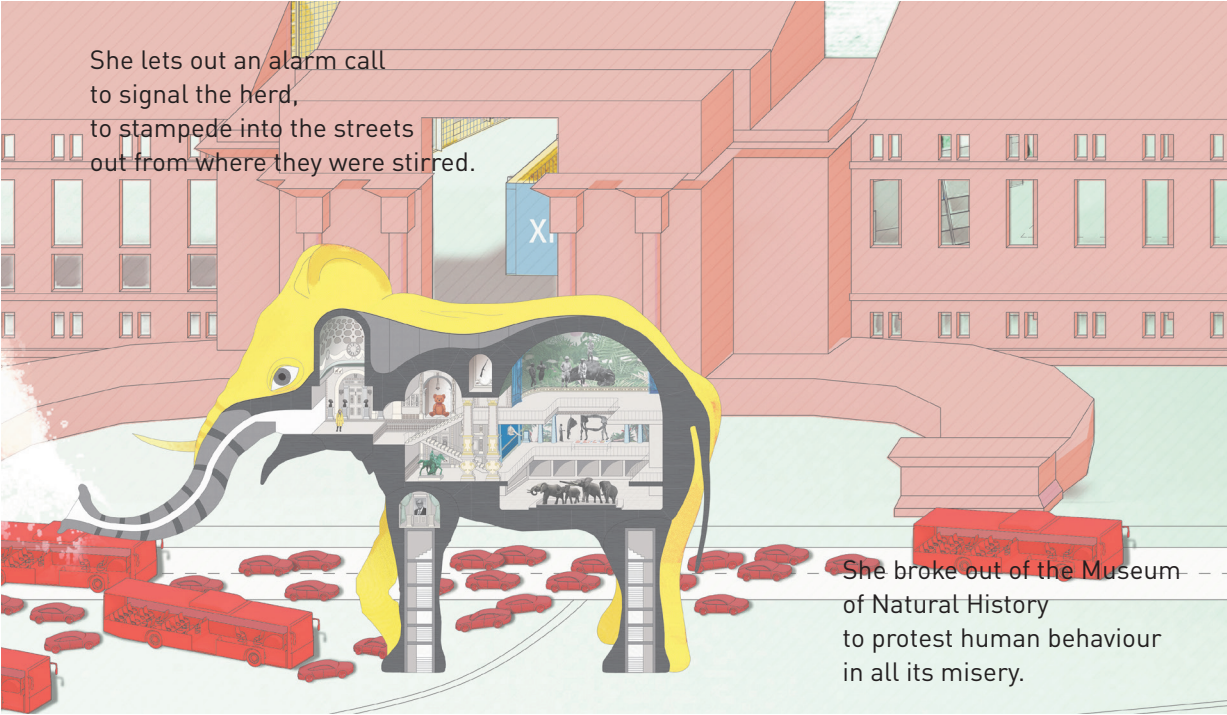
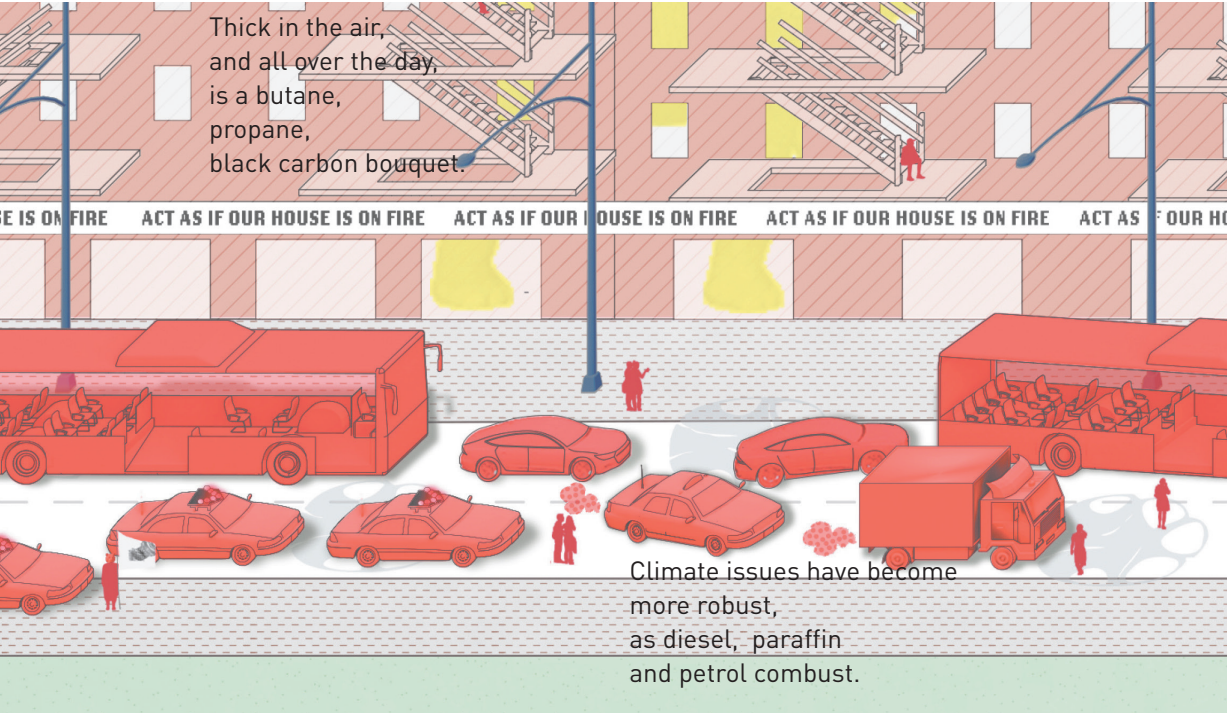
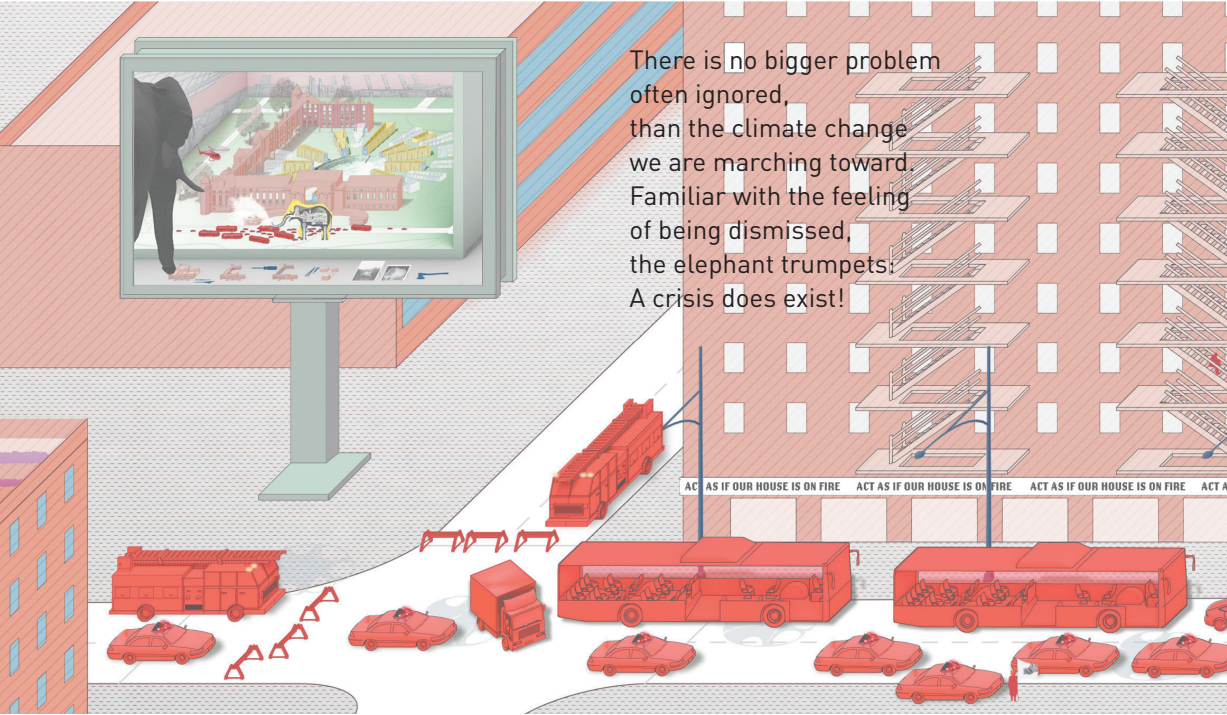


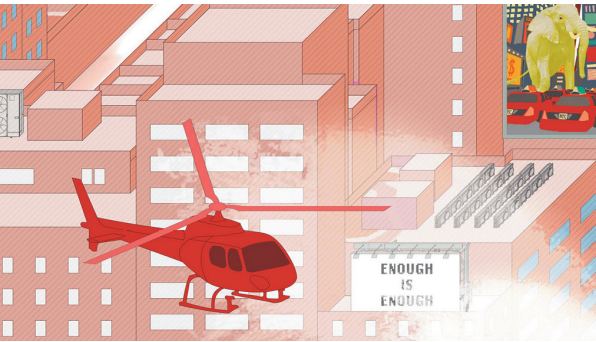
ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM

DESIGN EARTH
2021

A visitor to the museum notices small things, caught up in their own interests and the bias this brings. What does this allow to go unaddressed? The elephant in the room, as you may have guessed.

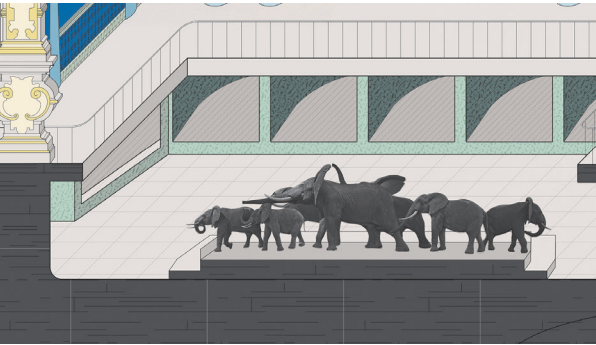
HALL OF AFR





26

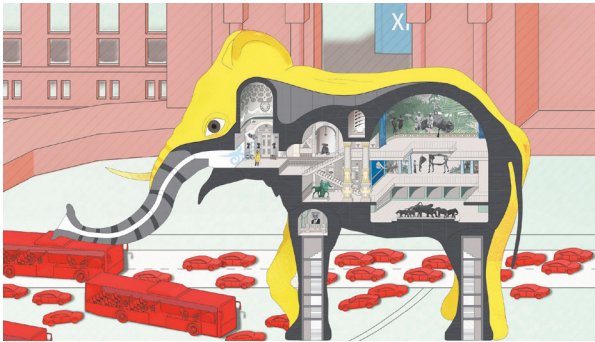
She occupies Wall Street
and protests in Times Square
while sirens serenade
and flies buzz in the air.
She raises her trunk
to sound a deafening drum,
“Enough is enough!
Surely you aren’t all just dumb.”



28

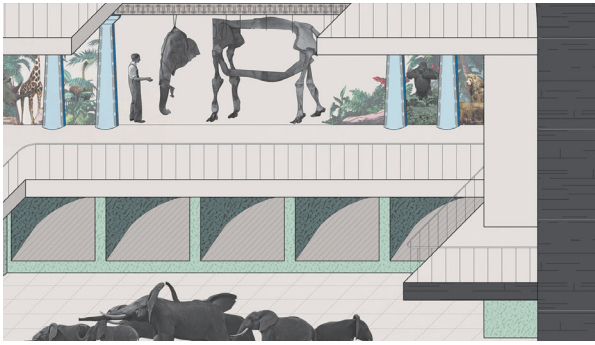
The Hall of African Mammals
is where they were taken,
waiting over a century
for a time to awaken.

“The Alarm” is the centrepiece
where their bodies were staged,
frozen in a nightmare
as if they were caged.



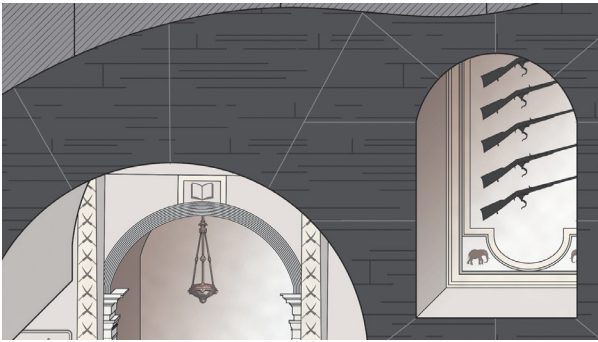
27

This matriarch elephant
and seven more died,
just so the museum
could become more alive.



29

Around the room,
other captive subjects stand by
within dioramas
that are stacked
two tiers high.
The rhinoceros,
gorilla,
ostrich
and lion
silently protest
in a perpetual die-in.



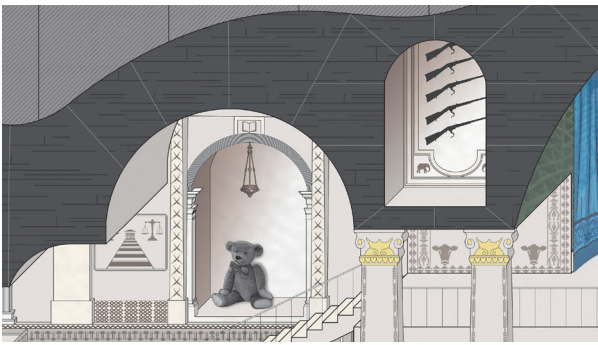
30

The elephant never forgets
the source of its scar.
“Speak softly and carry a big stick;
you will go far.”



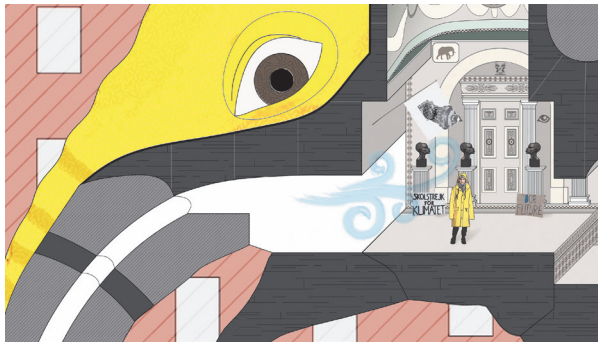
31

A celebrated conservationist
with a liking for hunting
is the American president
the Elephant was confronting.
“The Big Stick” is the rifle
President Roosevelt had in hand,
as he stalked the Elephant
across open land.
His son Kermit joined in
on the Africa expedition
and shot her small calf
taking after the politician.



32

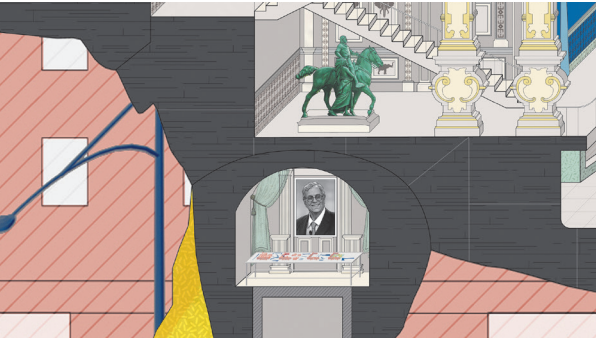
The Elephant twitches to life in the Africa Hall.
As if no time has passed,
she remembers it all.
Her reddish-brown eyes,
open to look museumgoers in the face.
She devours a book
that a companion had written,
on structures of power and knowledge
she did not fit in.
The Teddy Bear Patriarchy is a violent tale
of capitalism,
supremacy
and the white human male.



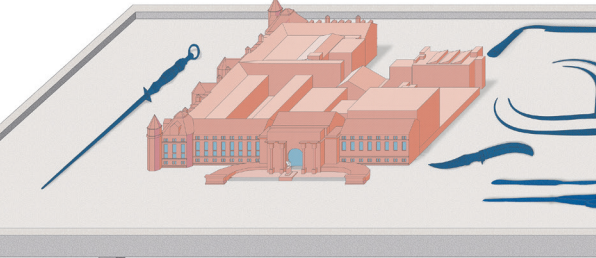
33

With eyes no longer blind
she sees what her body can make,
the world on her mind that no one can take.

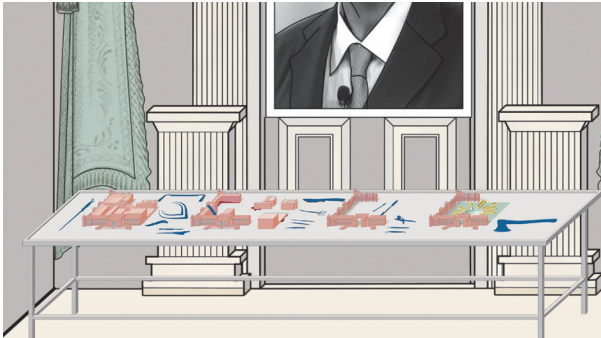
She looks around the room
and says, “The one thing I know,
is that the teddy bear patriarchy
will have to go!”



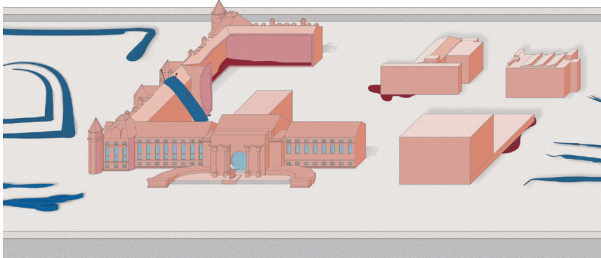
The creature denounces the stuffed Teddy and its monsters. She has had quite enough of environmental imposters. The equestrian statue and the plaque honouring David Koch was swallowed using her trunk shortly after she woke.



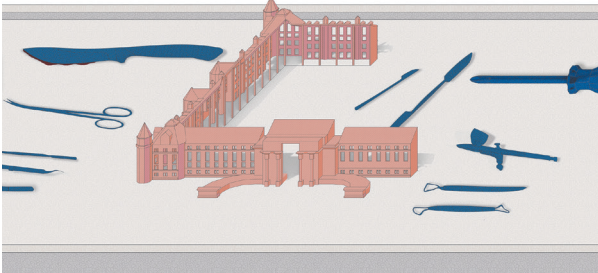
Like a calving iceberg, earthquake, or volcanic eruption, her trumpeting call thunders a long-distance disruption.



The mammal's belly rumbles with resonant demands: to decolonize, divest and dismantle, she firmly stands.



Her revival starts an autopsy fit for the ages where tools are used to dissect the museum in stages.

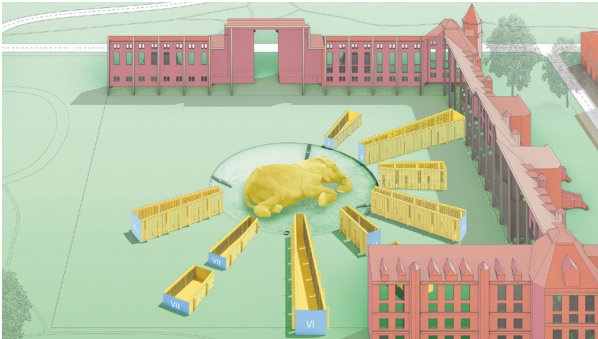


Natural History becomes an architectural taxidermy in a plan to make the most avid climate deniers squirm.



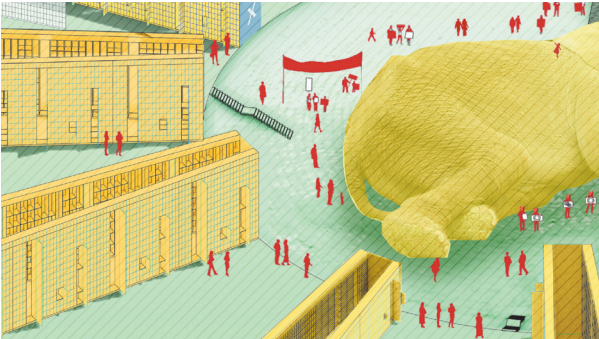
Only the museum's facade remains in place, to repair the damage to the very last trace.

It frames a graveyard where the Elephant can finally rest, with the enormous weight she has lifted right off of her chest.



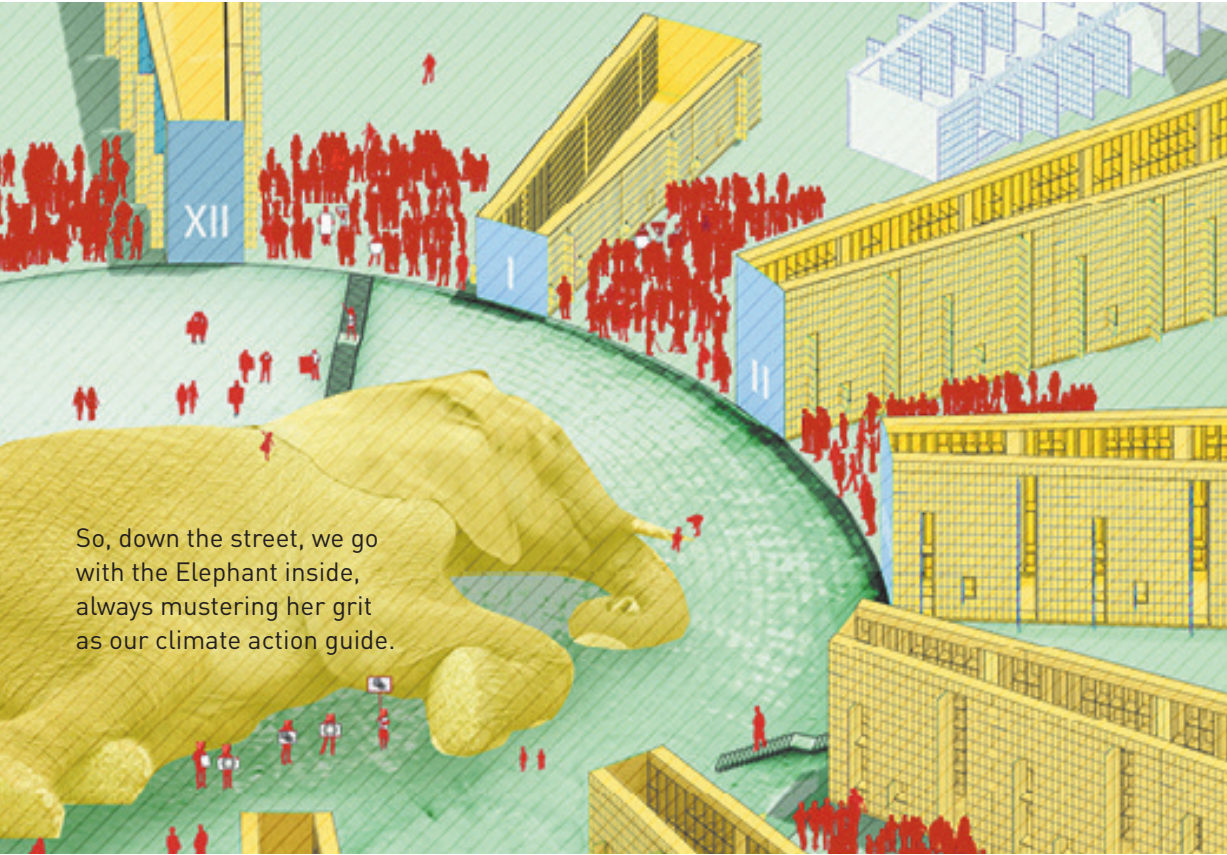
In the garden of a damaged planet, no collection is held, only the demand for action --that's why the Elephant rebelled!

A Climate Countdown 2 Degrees Clock will keep time and enforce the twelve years that remain for us to change course.

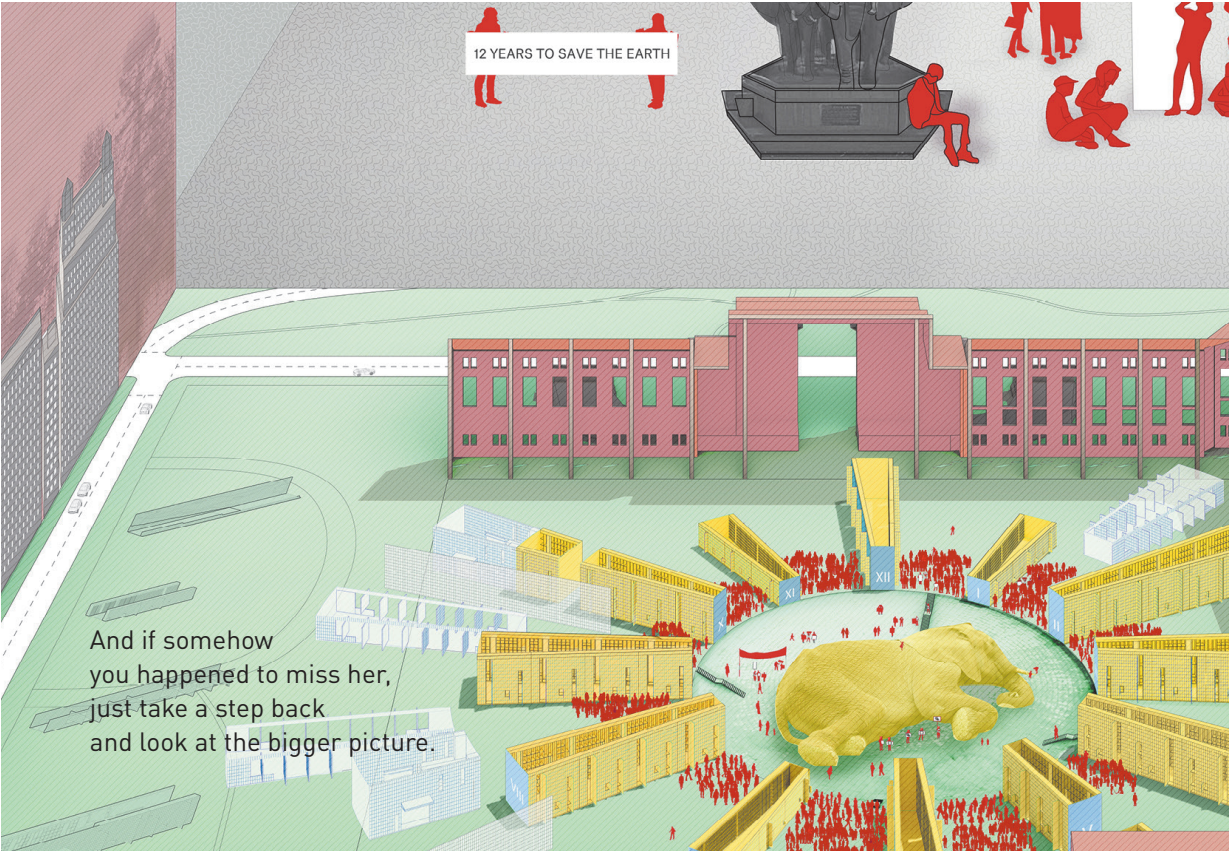


Each year, one bar of action counters the change that's been caused. The clock ticks and the bars tighten and it cannot be paused.

Around the Elephant's graveyard, the margins grow thin until the final alarm sounds and the endings begin.



So, down the street, we go with the Elephant inside, always mustering her grit as our climate action guide.



And if somehow you happened to miss her, just take a step back and look at the bigger picture.

BIO

DESIGN EARTH is a research practice that deploys speculative projects — drawing and narrative — to make the climate crisis public. It was founded by Rania Ghosn and El Hadi Jazairy. Rania (b. 1977 Lebanon) is an Associate Professor of Architecture and Urbanism at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. El Hadi (b. 1970 Algeria) is an Associate Professor of Architecture at the University of Michigan. Ghosn and Jazairy are authors of “Geographies of Trash” (2015), “Geostories: Another Architecture for the Environment” (2nd ed. 2020), and “The Planet After Geoengineering” (2021).

image 21-43: courtesy of DESIGN EARTH